Nebraska Football Win History (1890-2025)

Drew White - October 9, 2026

Section 1. Introduction

For this project I looked at the history of Nebraska Cornhuskers football. Nebraska used to be one of the best teams in the country but hasn't been very good in recent years. I wanted to use the data to see when that changed. I made six goals and built all of the charts in Excel.

I did not publish to Tableau Public since I used Excel. All of the charts and stories are in Section 6.

Excel workbook: Drew_White_Husker_Football_Visualization.xlsx (GitHub)

Section 2. Data Description

- **Domain:** College football (NCAA FBS). Each row is one season of Nebraska football.
- **Data file:** A season-by-season table with the year, head coach, conference, overall record, conference record, conference finish, bowl game, and final Coaches and AP poll rankings. The raw table had 137 rows and 9 columns, all stored as text.
- **Rows and columns used:** 136 rows (seasons 1890-2025) and 25 columns after cleaning.
- **Source:** Wikipedia - List of Nebraska Cornhuskers football seasons (retrieved October 9, 2026), which is based on the Nebraska Athletics Football Record Book.

Section 3. Data Cleaning Strategies

1. Removed the 2026 season because it was still in progress (2-0).
2. Split records like "9-2-1" into separate Wins, Losses, and Ties columns, for both overall and conference records.
3. Calculated win percentage, counting ties as half a win.
4. Removed the "T-" (tied) from rankings and standings and the "†" symbol from bowl names, then split bowl games into name and result (W/L).
5. Added Decade and Conference Era columns to group the data.
6. Checked my work: the cleaned totals (931-436-40) match the source's all-time record minus the 2026 games.

Section 4. Clean Dataset

The clean dataset has 136 rows and 25 columns. Some of the main columns are Season, Head_Coach, Conference, Wins, Losses, Ties, Win_Pct, Conf_Win_Pct, Bowl_Name, Bowl_Result, and AP_Final_Rank. Here are a few rows:

Season	Head coach	Conf.	W	L	T	Win %	Conf %	Bowl	Result	AP
1971	Bob Devaney	Big Eight	13	0	0	1.000	1.000	Orange	W	1
1995	Tom Osborne	Big Eight	12	0	0	1.000	1.000	Fiesta	W	1
2012	Bo Pelini	Big Ten	10	4	0	0.714	0.875	Capital One	L	25

Season	Head coach	Conf.	W	L	T	Win %	Conf %	Bowl	Result	AP
2025	Matt Rhule	Big Ten	7	6	0	0.538	0.444	Las Vegas	L	

Section 5. Visualization Tools

I used Microsoft Excel for everything. The dataset was small enough that Excel worked well, and I'm comfortable with it. I used SUMIF and COUNTIF formulas to make summary tables for each goal and then made charts from those tables (line, column, bar, stacked column, and scatter).

Excel workbook: https://github.com/Drew-White09/husker-football/blob/main/Drew_White_Husker_Football_Visualization.xlsx

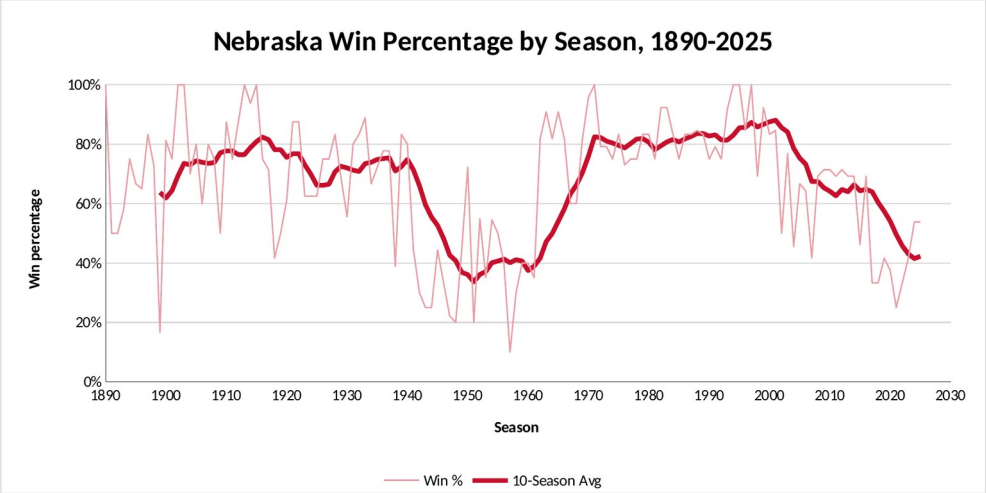
GitHub repository: https://github.com/Drew-White09/husker-football

Section 6. Visualizations and Stories

6.1 Goal 1: Win % Over Time

Goal: Show how Nebraska's win percentage has changed from 1890 to 2025.

Chart: Line chart with a 10-season moving average (Excel).

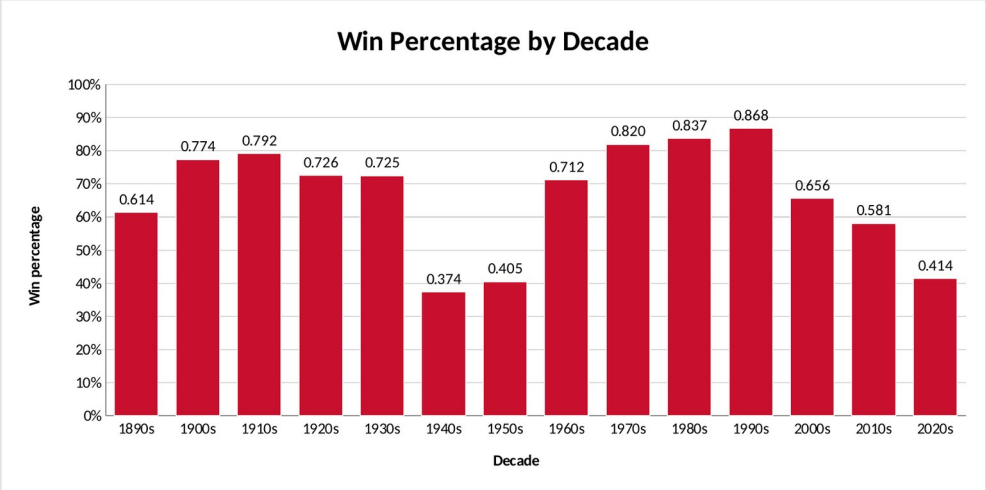


Story: The 10-season average shows three big periods. Nebraska won a lot early on, then hit its low point in the 1940s and 50s (.337 average by 1951). After Bob Devaney was hired in 1962 the line shot up and peaked at .881 from 1992-2001. Since then it has gone down, and the 2016-2025 average (.423) is the lowest since 1962.

6.2 Goal 2: Win % by Decade

Goal: Compare win percentage by decade to find the best and worst decades.

Chart: Column chart with data labels (Excel).

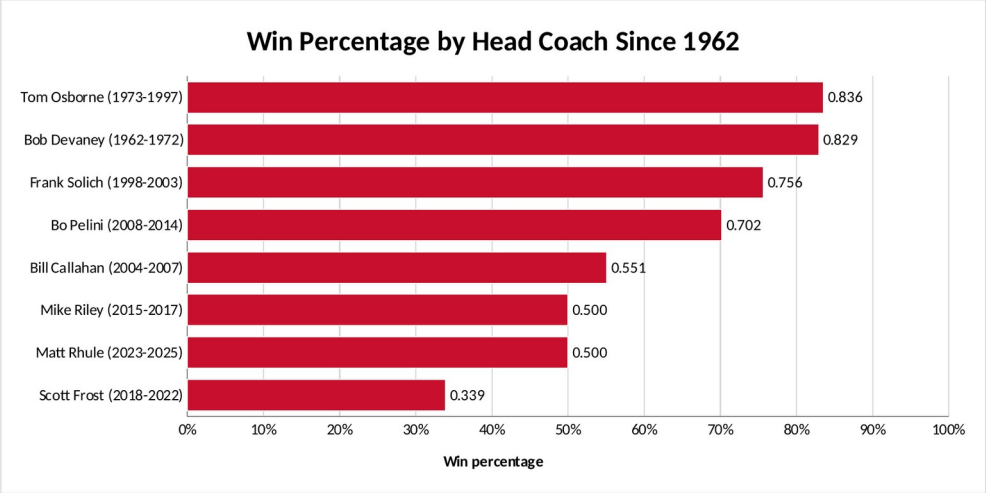


Story: The 1990s were the best decade at .868, and the 70s, 80s, and 90s were all above .800. The 1940s were the worst (.374). Every decade since the 1990s has been worse than the one before it, and the 2020s are at .414 so far.

6.3 Goal 3: Head Coaches Since 1962

Goal: Compare the win percentage of every head coach since 1962.

Chart: Bar chart sorted from highest to lowest (Excel).

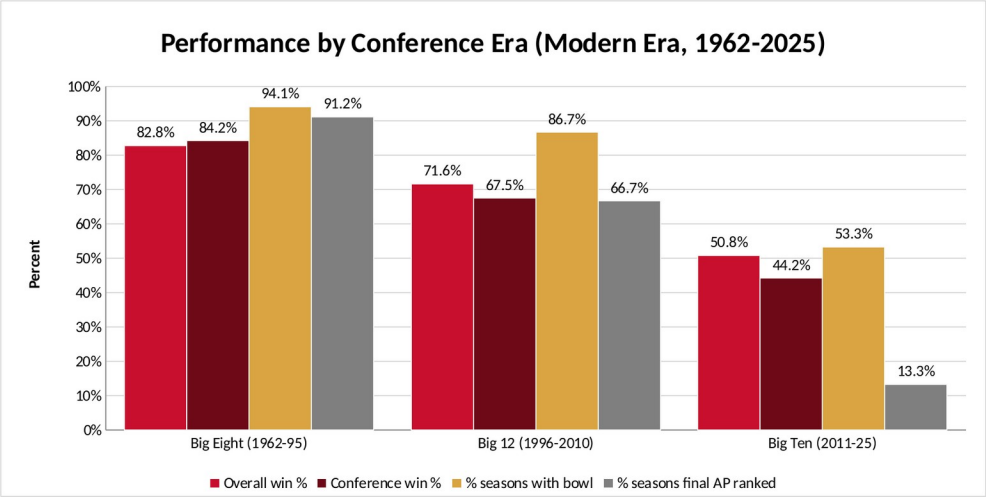


Story: Osborne (.836) and Devaney (.829) are way ahead of everyone else. Osborne went to a bowl and finished ranked in all 25 of his seasons. Every coach since 2015 is at .500 or below, and Scott Frost (.339) is the lowest.

6.4 Goal 4: Conference Eras

Goal: Compare Nebraska's results in the Big Eight, Big 12, and Big Ten.

Chart: Clustered column chart with four measures (Excel).

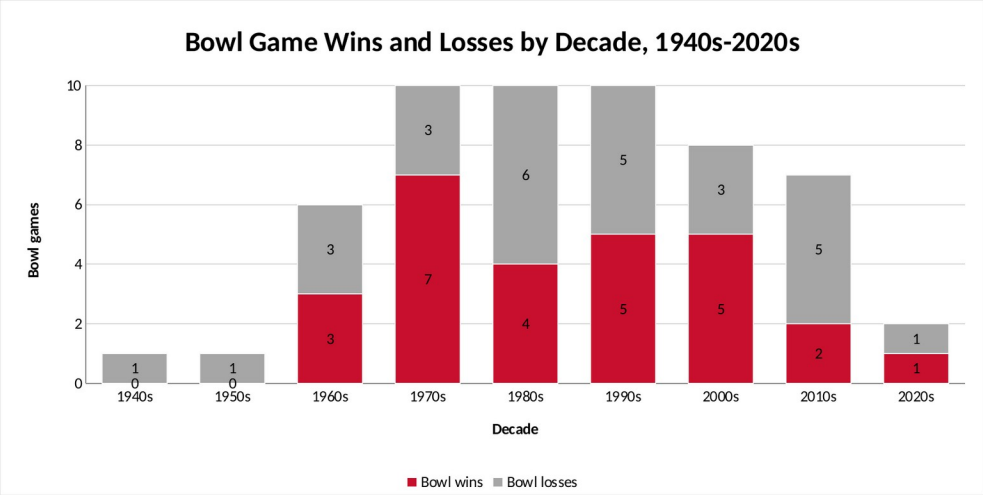


Story: Every measure goes down from the Big Eight to the Big 12 to the Big Ten. The biggest drop is in rankings: 91% of Big Eight seasons ended ranked, but only 13% of Big Ten seasons did. The drop started before the Big Ten though, since the team had bad years in 2004 and 2007.

6.5 Goal 5: Bowl Games

Goal: Show bowl wins and losses by decade.

Chart: Stacked column chart (Excel).

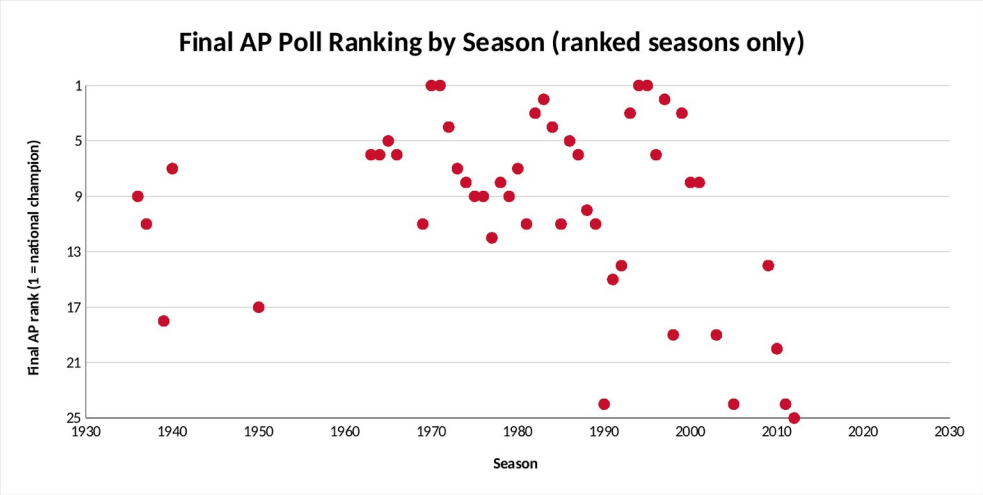


Story: Nebraska went to 35 bowl games in a row from 1969 to 2003, so the 70s, 80s, and 90s all have 10. The 1970s were the best at 7-3. The all-time bowl record is 27-28, but only 3-5 in the Big Ten. The team didn't go to a bowl from 2017 to 2023.

6.6 Goal 6: Final AP Rankings

Goal: Show Nebraska's final AP ranking each season to see when they were a national power.

Chart: Scatter plot with #1 at the top (Excel).



Story: From 1969 to 2001 Nebraska was ranked every year (33 in a row) and finished #1 four times. After 2001 the dots drop and spread out. The last time they finished ranked was 2012 (#25), so it's been 13 seasons.

Section 7. Conclusions

- Nebraska's best years were from 1962 to 2001 under Bob Devaney, Tom Osborne, and Frank Solich. They were ranked 33 years in a row and went to 35 straight bowl games.
- The decline started in the early 2000s while Nebraska was still in the Big 12, not when they joined the Big Ten in 2011. Joining the Big Ten made it worse, though (conference win % went from 67.5% to 44.2%).
- Rankings dropped faster than wins. Nebraska hasn't finished ranked since 2012.
- Every coach since 2015 has a .500 record or worse.
- The last two seasons (7-6 both years with bowl games) are the first sign of things getting better.

A next step would be to add recruiting rankings and strength of schedule to see if those explain the drop.